

Markdown Repository

INTRODUCTION

Markdown repository, savvy social media use, and programming of lectures and film screenings about Mumbai's architectural heritage have encouraged people to pause and photograph rather than merely pass by iconic buildings. Art Deco Mumbai's founder, Atul Kumar, cites recent engagement from younger Indians as evidence that the group's outreach is working, bringing "curiosity, sensitization and appreciation of the City's Deco architecture, which are crucial steps in enabling conservation." [1]

"Mumbai's never-ending quest for space threatens heritage structures integral to the city's history, raising questions about the balance between conservation and development."

CONSERVATION EFFORTS

These platforms have the potential to combine research with awareness, which could lead to neighborhoods and precincts receiving heritage status and zoning laws that encourage sensitive development. Mumbai's most significant recent conservation success story was UNESCO recognition of the Victorian Gothic and Art Deco Ensemble as a World Heritage site in 2018, which Art Deco Mumbai helped make possible.

It will take citizens' participation and government planning to incorporate heritage into the future of Mumbai's urban identity. Through his work on MHCC, Mr. Dilawari has concluded that the government's main responsibility is to build a "comprehensive conservation development plan which respects the full ecosystem." [2] This could include public-private partnerships in funding for conservation, citywide zoning guidelines, and recognition of areas as heritage precincts. Though battles for space will continue to define Mumbai, efforts to bolster awareness about and accessibility to the city's built heritage indicate that citizens may prioritize preservation alongside development.

BACKGROUND ON AUTHORS

Aaran Patel is a master in public policy student at the John F. Kennedy School of Government at Harvard University. He is concentrating on social and urban policy and on the intersection between education and the environment. Before HKS, he worked with Teach For India at the organizational and classroom levels. He received his BA from Pomona College in 2015, where he double-majored in history and politics.

ENDNOTES

1. Atul Kumar, founder of Art Deco Mumbai, email interview with the author.
2. Vikas Dilawari (conservation architect and member of the Mumbai Heritage Conservation Committee) email interview with the author.

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[2] Vikas Dilawari (conservation architect and member of the Mumbai Heritage Conservation Committee) email interview with the author.